

PATNA | Jailhouse Stock

With the economic downturn ringing alarm bells across the world, many professionals consider this the time to stuff cash into the mattress. This seems true for the high and mighty as well, at least one of whom seems following the dictum rather literally, never mind the fact that he is still doing time. On March 13, a police raiding party seized Rs 13,000 from RJD MP and jailbird Mohammad Shahabuddin, who had concealed the cash under his mattress in Siwan jail. Five cellphones, three mobile chargers, perfume bottles and ganja were also recovered from the jail premises during the raid. This is not the first time when banned articles have been found on the honourable MP. Last year a raid had led to the seizure of mobile phones from his cell. The MP was sentenced to life imprisonment in May 2007 for the kidnapping and alleged murder of CPI(M-L) worker Chhote Lal Gupta in 1999. Incidentally, Shahabuddin has sought the suspension of his sentence to



CASH WAS FOUND IN SHAHABUDDIN'S PRISON CELL

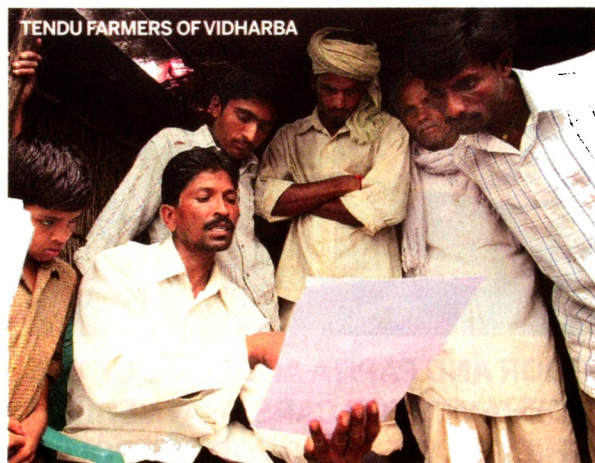
enable him to contest parliamentary elections. Siwan district officials, meanwhile, have rejected the MP's plea to re-register him as a voter. His name was deleted from the voter's list in 2005 when he was absconding. District officials argue that a convict cannot contest polls. Some downturn for the don.

by Amitabh Srivastava

Long Wait

The BJP's plan to pit a celebrity to crack the Congress's hold on Delhi has come unstuck. After the BJP dithered for weeks, Hema Malini has declined to go into pitched battle against the Congress's Ajay Maken. Moral of the story: don't keep the Dream Girl waiting.

MUMBAI | Leafed Out



Almost 40 lakh tribal tendu farmers of Vidharba have threatened to boycott the Lok Sabha polls over the non-payment of bonus and corruption by local politicians. Tendu leaves are used to make 'bidis'. "The decision can affect 15 constituencies across the state," says Vinod Tiwari, general secretary of Vidharbha Jan Andolan Samiti. The workers are miffed over non-payment of their bonus for the 2007-08 season. "The list of beneficiaries includes local Congress workers and NCP politicians, not the real tendu workers. This is organised crime and an atrocity against the poor tribals," says Tiwari.

by Aditi Pai



golden pumpkins

IT'S FINALLY curtains for the real-life soap opera of love, longing and loathing between former Haryana deputy chief minister Chander Mohan-turned-Chand Mohammad and his second wife Anuradha Bali-turned-Fiza. Less than four months after their covert-and-consummate marital shenani-

YASBANT NEGI



CHAND AND FIZA

gans turned into a slanging match through TV channels, the London-ensconced groom called Fiza on her cellphone and repeated 'talaq' thrice, going through the Islam-mandated motion of divorce, following it up with a terse talaq SMS. The runaway groom's step came in the wake of the Mohali police inquiry that gave him a clean chit over Fiza's allegations of rape, cheating and intimidation. Fiza has vowed to move court to seek justice. But she may have already lost the plot in her much televised rave-and-rant affair with the man whom she had publicly adored as more 'charming than the moon'. by Ramesh Vinayak